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Definitions and Variations of Political Communication

Chapter 2 provides an overview of a number of key concepts in political communication, as well as details how political communication looks different in various media and political systems in countries and regions around the world. This chapter provides a guiding definition of political communication, details shifts in media and political systems with technological change, and discusses the relationship between platforms, political communication, and political processes. It concludes by providing a model of platforms and political communication as they are embedded in media and political systems and shaped by historical, cultural, social, and economic forces, which they in turn shape.

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- define political communication
- contextualize political communication from a global perspective
- understand the transition from the mass media era to the platform age
- explain the relationship between political systems, platforms, and political communication
- reflect on how political communication is mediated.

2.1 Introduction

This book is about political communication. And, broadly speaking, political communication is communication about politics. Even more, communication *creates* what people understand to be political. By *communication*, this book means any form of symbolic expression, whether it entails spoken words, texts, visual symbols, digital videos, or, most likely, some combination of all the above.

Some of these forms of communication have long lineages of being important politically, while newer ones are central to the ways we communicate about politics today. For example, oration has long been a preferred form of authoritative address for political elites, whereas digital video has exploded in popularity globally in the last decade. Digital video has become a means for everything from campaigns introducing candidates to everyday people documenting war and police abuses. Indeed, we are awash in new forms of storytelling through multimedia on global video-hosting platforms such as YouTube (which has more than 460 million users in India alone) and Youku (more than 500 million users in

China). Whether printed or digital, texts provide vehicles for political ideas and debate, and they can range from newspapers, books, and the white papers of think tanks to tweets, Facebook posts, and pamphlets circulated by social movements. Visual symbols include everything from flags and images on Instagram to campaign and party logos and emojis.

As such, *communication* is an expansive concept and takes many different forms through different media, including the human voice. Communication is something people do verbally and non-verbally all the time, beginning the moment they enter the world. Communication becomes *symbolic* when people develop the capacity to create, convey, and understand meaning. What makes it *political* is when communication concerns the distribution of power or resources in a society; who the members of that society are and should be; the problems that collectively need to be identified and solved; the ways we should live and what values and goals we should have; the very nature of the community itself and its relations with other communities; or who legitimately holds power and what the nature of that power is. In short, politics deals with relations, power, identity, and decision-making.

This book takes as its starting point that *political communication* concerns public life – the things we share with others and our relations with others. This is an expansive definition, and deliberately so. It includes not just the things we take for granted as political – such as elections and policymaking. But also those things that people *want* us to have a collective response to, whether they concern manners, morals, or issues – anything that relates to our ways of living together.

Even ostensibly private things can suddenly become matters of public concern, depending on what people talk about when they talk about politics – or disappear from public concern when they stop talking about politics (Wells et al. 2017). What is considered private versus public is often the result of communicative struggles that are inherently political.

SPOTLIGHTED CASES

Here are a few examples of how what was formerly private became political. Women in countries around the world successfully redefined what had once been commonly seen as violent “private” spousal relations as “domestic violence,” transforming it into a public issue. Even further, naming what occurred between husbands and wives as *violence* was also a broader political argument about *equality* that defines how we should treat one another in private and public life and what the role of the state should be with respect to protecting its citizens. The same goes for Black activists pointing to discrimination in private real estate markets, religious advocates arguing for public standards of dress or prayer in public schools, and lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, queer/questioning, intersex, or asexual plus (LGBTQIA+) activists fighting for equality in labor markets and public accommodations.

In addition, things that we do not ordinarily think about as being political are full of political meaning. Politics is all around us. Think about entertainment programs that convey ideas about how to live and who has money and power, even if these things are tangential to the main plot. Think about TikTok videos that celebrate selfexpressive joy and free expression. Think about all the athletes around the world who knelt during their national anthems or wore black armbands during “end racism” campaigns and global Black

Lives Matter protests. And think of all the advocates around the world who argue that representation – in sports, entertainment, media, corporate board rooms, and education – matters for the types of future that children believe they can achieve.

2.2 Types of Political Communication

Accordingly, the *types* of actors that produce and engage in political communication are many and diverse – whether they are people, organizations, institutions, media, or even technologies. Indeed, *everyone* or *everything* is a potential political communicator if their expression relates to matters of public concern – or argues that something should be a matter of public concern. When a member of the public gives an interview to a journalist to express her concerns about a polluting business nearby, it is political communication. When a woman comes forward publicly about a harassing famous boss, she is engaging in political communication. When a person comes out publicly as LGBTQIA+, they are engaging in political communication in affirming who they are in ways that have political implications (Garretson 2018). When a religious person declares a set of tenets that they believe a moral or just society as a whole should adhere to – that is political communication. When people produce entertainment media that represent immigrant lives and communities, this is inherently political communication as well.

And when a global platform company such as Meta (formerly Facebook) designs an algorithm to remove what it defines as “racist” content, someone builds a bot on Twitter to try to shape public opinion around an election, or TikTok’s algorithms shape the “for you pages” of its users in ways that influence how they think about their social identities, these are also forms of political communication. Indeed, not only are the corporate employees and engineers behind the policies and algorithms engaging in political communication, these technologies, such as bots and algorithms, are engaging in political communication by restricting, promoting, or shaping the incentives for certain types of content (Brevini & Swiatek 2020; Noble 2018; Tripodi 2022).

While political communication is all around us all the time, there are *institutionalized* political communicators who play more defined, specialized, and routine roles in journalistic, political, and public communication processes. These types of communicators are at the heart of this book. By “institutionalized,” we mean that certain political actors play defined roles in political processes and communicate in generally patterned and routinized ways that persist over time (Cook 1998; Schudson 2002). These political communicators include journalists, political pundits, political parties and elected representatives, social media managers, political candidates, political advertising agencies, think tanks, political marketers, political public relations practitioners, press secretaries, advocacy and social movement organizations, government agencies, transnational bodies such as the European Union – and many, many more besides. These are the individuals and organizations that address publics routinely and play established and often well-defined roles in public debate, electoral politics, and governance processes across the world, as well as the creation, circulation, and diffusion of ideas and arguments that shape what people see as matters of public concern. This includes the issues that need to be addressed and their causes, ideas how politics should be structured, and arguments about who has legitimate power and status.

The addressing of publics and debates within public spheres take shape through *media* and *genres* that are institutionalized according to particular settings and contexts for political

communication. One way to think about media is in terms of *technologies* and the *organizations, institutions, and cultures* that surround them. To take an example, television sets are forms of media, but to truly understand television we also need to consider the *content* that they display, the *organizations* that manufacture and produce content for them, the *cultures* (Brock 2020) that shape that content and norms for their use, and the regulatory and economic landscapes that govern how television sets are produced and what content can be shown, how, and when. *Genres* are patterned ways of communicating that exist across media, which are in turn also shaped by the organizations that produce media, the economic and other reasons they have for doing so (such as audience demand), and the regulations that shape discourse in the public sphere. Think about how news broadcasts usually follow a particular, patterned format, with an anchor who narrates headlines according to shared standards of newsworthiness. There are many different genres in political communication. What appears on the news pages of a newspaper differs, for instance, from what appears in the opinion section and on cable news. Taken together, genres constitute the patterned ways in which political and media elites and everyday people alike express, discuss, and debate public issues.

Finally, there are often defined settings and contexts that shape political communication. How elected officials address parliaments or other governing bodies is different from how they speak at a campaign rally or to their colleagues behind the scenes in legislative offices. Declarations of war, funerals, and public health crises are all contexts that call for staid, somber, and authoritative addresses, respectively, by political and state leaders, whereas other settings (such as national holidays) might be causes for celebration or uplift. Citizens speak differently in legislative hearings than in public meetings. Citizen discourse also differs substantially across platforms, with their different social norms and rules around things such as anonymity. For example, on platforms such as Facebook that require real names, people can be more cautious about expressing controversial opinions, given the ways “contexts collapse” (Marwick & boyd 2011), drawing work, social, and familial ties together. Different political and media actors, meanwhile, have different norms and expectations for political expression, especially when communicating across fields. Think about the often deferential way journalists communicate when asking questions of political leaders, versus their approach to citizens such as victims of a crime or eyewitnesses to a natural disaster.

2.3 Overview: Varieties of Political Communication across the Globe

Political communication is not the same everywhere and for everyone, of course. Historical, social, economic, and cultural contexts matter profoundly for political communication, including shaping who has power in societies. Political communication is textured by different state and regime types, political systems, party systems, electoral systems, media systems, and journalism cultures (e.g. Esser & Pfetsch 2020). One way to illustrate this is the paradox of the “Americanization” of election campaigns. On the one hand, elements of US presidential campaigns spill over and influence campaigns in other Western democracies, such as in the use of professional public relations experts or social media to obtain microdonations and for microtargeting. On the other, campaign managers from outside the US will tell you that, no, unfortunately they cannot just copy-and-paste the playbooks from the Obama 2012, Trump 2016, or Biden 2020 campaigns, as they

would not work in the specific political setting or media system in their country (e.g. Lilleker et al. 2020).

In fact, US elections are unique among Western democracies. The presidential system gives extraordinary power to the White House, and a polarized two-party system means that parties do not share power in governing coalitions, but that the winner (however slim the victory) takes it all (the presidency or House and Senate majorities). The presidential prize that can be won (or lost) is so big that both sides spend enormous amounts of resources in the race, focused on only a handful of states due to an election system based not on the popular vote, but a complicated and anachronistic institution: the Electoral College. Because of this specific setting, innovations often arise in US presidential election campaigns – there are abundant financial resources, strong incentives to implement new technologies and to move beyond the known strategies, comparatively few regulations (especially compared to Europe), and no reason to be soft on your opponent (Kreiss 2016).

Compare this to the situation in Switzerland, for instance. Here we find a multi-party system in a parliamentary democracy premised on power sharing. After each election, the parties in parliament elect a government, the Federal Council, a collegial body of seven members with equal rights. The presidency rotates among them each year, but it is the council as whole that collectively serves as head of state. Since 1891, the idea behind this government formation has been to include all major political movements in the government. This, of course, means that there is no opposition – all major parties are part of the government, and they govern by the consensus principle. It is also a political tradition to not vote out a sitting member of the Federal Council. Thus, elections hardly ever change anything – parties can hardly win or lose anything, and politicians meet again in roughly the same coalitions after the election. It is also impossible to vote out the government. Against this backdrop, there are few incentives to spend many resources on campaigning or pursuing innovations, or to be tough on your competitors. This is an entirely different story when it comes to referendum campaigns, which is the Swiss playground for political conflicts and ideological battles.

These two cases illustrate how very differently the stage can be set for political communication – *even* given the fact that the US and Switzerland are both wealthy Western democracies with highly media-literate and technology-savvy citizens. There is much more variation in the world beyond these two countries, of course. For example, the role of platforms in political life can look very different across countries. Even as social media and platforms influence democratic political change in some countries (Howard & Hussain 2013), some leaders have proven remarkably adept at holding on to power, and even at dying in office, at whatever cost. These leaders often use informational tactics on platforms to stifle the political opposition and democratic movements.

SPOTLIGHTED CASES

Despite early optimism that the Internet would bring democracy to countries around the world, authoritarian and anti-democratic leaders have adapted to changing media environments. Some African countries, such as the Democratic Republic of Congo, Chad, Cameroon, and Zimbabwe, have blocked internet access in the wake of anti-government protests – despite government denials. Meanwhile, even amid sweeping changes in media and technology, authoritarian leaders have died in office (Chad's Idriss Déby), have had to be forced out via a military coup (Robert Mugabe of Zimbabwe), or, as in the case of Cameroon's Paul Biya, who has held power since 1975, have established de facto one-party systems and simply refuse to give up power.

Indeed, some political leaders have proven markedly adept at bending information environments to suit their will. Critics and researchers have documented Russian President Vladimir Putin's ability to control informational dynamics within his own country through propaganda and other manipulative tactics that have enabled him to maintain and expand power domestically, even while exporting these tactics abroad to strategically weaken his adversaries (Cooper 2020; Miazhevich 2018). In other countries, such as Venezuela, state-run media outlets sit alongside commercial media and social media that represent various groups and ideological perspectives vying for political power, dynamics which undemocratic leaders work to manipulate to shore up power (Lupien 2013).

Most political communication research originates from and focuses on democracies – those countries or transnational entities, such as the European Union, that hold elections and protect the basic political rights of individuals and associations (what scholars call “liberal democracy”). However, scholars have increasingly come to realize that democracy is a matter of degree, and states are always in a process of becoming or unbecoming, just as authoritarian states face constant pressure to change as well. Between consolidated and comparatively stable democracies on one side and totalitarian states on the other, we find many forms of “defective democracies” (Merkel 2004) (such as in new states where institutions are imperfectly realized), “hybrid regimes” (Bogaards 2009) or “anocracies” (Pate 2020) (hybrid or mixed regimes featuring democratic and authoritarian elements, such as Nigeria), “democracies with adjectives” (Collier & Levitsky 1997) (such as military-backed democratic regimes), or democratic “backsliding” (Haggard & Kaufman 2021) (the erosion of democratic or civic institutions in countries around the world, such as the United States). Democracies emerge and they can die (Keane 2009; Levitsky & Ziblatt 2018). Across history, democracies are the exception, not the rule, and therefore they should not be taken for granted. For their part, authoritarian systems can be overthrown or gradually shift toward democracy, or break down into war and ethnic cleansing.

There is also political communication in all of these mixed and non-democratic states, of course. Consider the extreme cases of authoritarian, totalitarian, or one-party states. Political communication can include everything from state propaganda, leader proclamations, state-friendly journalism, and military parades to the subtle, coded communication of opposition groups, independent press organizations, and discontented citizens who cannot dissent openly. In these countries, explicit censorship means that journalists and political activists cannot write and publish as they see fit. It also means that

criticism in politics, journalism, literature, poetry, and theatre plays is expressed “between the lines,” and that citizens and activists use coded language in everyday life and on social media (Tilly et al. 2020).

As noted above, digital platforms were initially praised for democratizing closed regimes, or at least creating the conditions for democracy to thrive. Researchers and journalists held up paradigmatic examples such as the democratic movements that swept the Middle East and North Africa in the early 2010s (the “Arab Spring”) as examples of this democratizing relationship between information and communication technologies and authoritarian regimes (e.g. Howard 2010; Mutsvairo & Bebawi 2022). Since that time, however, there has been considerable rethinking. It might be less dangerous to hold up a cardboard sign in public (and run away once the police show up) than to voice discontent or mobilize protest online, traceable by IP addresses or digital forensics.

States such as China have exercised control over what their populations can access in terms of information, including on American-run platforms that desire to do business in them, and regularly engage in tactics to manipulate digital information and social processes (Field et al. 2018; Lu & Pan 2021; Pan 2019). Indeed, what content standards US-based companies should have across vastly different regimes is an important debate in contemporary political communication research and Western policymaking discourse (e.g. Helberger et al. 2018). At the same time, contests between platforms for market share often reflect larger geopolitical struggles between states over values and economics. While Meta’s WhatsApp has long been widely used across Africa, in recent years WeChat, owned by a Chinese company, has been making inroads, aided in part by the growing influence of China’s political and economic supremacy across the continent. In the United States, there are fierce debates over the Chinese company-owned TikTok potentially being a tool for influence over the American public, in addition to widespread fears about the safety and security of data about Americans on the platform.

Meanwhile, processes of democratization can be interrupted or reversed. Scholars have established various definitions and measurements of democratic consolidation (Coppedge et al. 2020; Schedler 2001). The progress of democratization and the quality of democracy depend on factors such as the guarantee of civil liberties, the rule of law, the resilience of the electoral system, the checks and balances within the political system, political participation, and the role of the military and potential anti-system actors in the state. Researchers have ways of assessing and comparing all of these things through democracy indices, such as Freedom House, the Bertelsmann Transformation Index, the Sustainable Governance Indicators, or the Varieties of Democracies index.

In the past two decades, there has also been an explosion of work on democratic decay, backsliding, and crisis (Bennett & Livingston 2021; Levitsky & Ziblatt 2018), amid growing evidence and widespread concern that even apparently consolidated democracies are under threat from the pressures of inequality, polarization, would-be autocratic leaders, anti-democratic parties, or, most dramatically, coups that take power through force (Haggard & Kaufman 2021). At the same time, many of these things are taking shape amid unprecedented movements for racial and social justice that threaten dominant interests and privileged social groups, which can provoke intense backlash (Hajnal 2021) – precisely the story of the attempted coup in the US on January 6, 2021 (Cline Center 2021).

As such, it is best to see political systems as always in flux. The past two centuries, after all, have witnessed the gradual expansion of suffrage in countries around the world, to

include men without property, people from non-dominant racial and religious groups, and women. In countries such as Argentina, democratic governments were overthrown (some with the help of the United States) and then reinstated through elections. And yet, even these things are far from settled, with the resurgence of right-wing, exclusionary movements in countries across the globe that seek to restrict citizenship and reinforce rigid hierarchies across social groups. For example, since 2019, India, considered the world's most populous democracy, has experienced considerable backsliding on the heels of a Hindu nationalist leader and political party consolidating power.

Democracy must be upheld through laws and institutions as much as norms – including those that shape political communication. History has made it clear that democracies prove fragile when political communicators cease to respect the legitimacy of the opposition; undermine electoral accountability; stoke racial and ethnic divisions in the service of protecting or pursuing unequal power; deny people equality; circumscribe citizenship or rights to favor certain racial, ethnic, or religious groups; or refuse ever to compromise. The relationship between these things and platforms, social media, and technology more generally is complicated and actively debated. There are clearly challenges to forms of authoritarian rule when people communicate shared grievances and organize, mobilize, and make themselves visible to one another. Technology offers social movements important new opportunities for mobilization (Bennett & Segerberg 2013). At the same time, digitally enabled mobilization does not necessarily translate into the institutions and organizations necessary for durable democratic change (Tufekci 2017).

Over the past decade, there has also been an explosion of work on platforms and threats to democracy. A conclusion of this research is that platforms are tools for those contesting power, especially elites who seek to stoke and inflame division in pursuit of political advantage. But platforms are not neutral tools – through their design, policies, monetization strategies, and power over attention they amplify certain forms of political speech (such as the emotional and extreme) and dramatically lower the costs of some types of communication (such as video). These things in turn provide opportunities for non-institutional media and political interests, which has meant more rapidly mobilizing social movements and threats to institutional parties, including their loss of control over, for example, nominating contests. It has also meant increased opportunities for coordination across shared political interests (such as ruling parties and elites and organized digital movements that work in tandem with them). Even all this is complicated. The same platforms that facilitate movements for democracy and justice also create conditions for disinformation and propaganda in the service of power – undermining the tolerance, accountability, and faith in institutions at the center of democracy. Non-institutional media and parties are democratizing in some contexts, and levers of power for authoritarians in others.

In sum, changes in media and technology do not necessarily bring democracy. There are many varieties of political communication – in democracies and authoritarian countries, in political systems with 2 or 17 political parties in the legislative branch, and in nations with public service broadcasters, private media duopolies, or some pluralistic mix. Political communication is constantly evolving in response to changes in media and political systems – even as political communication changes media and political systems in turn. Let's now look in greater detail at the relationship between political systems and political communication.

2.4 Political Systems and Political Communication

The “political” can be thought of generally along three dimensions: the *polity* – which includes things such as constitutions and institutional designs that are structural (i.e., they provide the rules of the game); *politics* – the arena of conflicts between political actors; and *policy* – often the aim of political conflicts, such as the passage (or revocation) of laws and regulations.

All three are interconnected. The design of a political system impacts the goals of political actors, how they behave and communicate, and what they are incentivized to do. Political practices and norms, such as around conflict negotiation, that are part of the arena of politics impact how, and even whether, new policies can enter the political agenda. Political actors create the details of policies in line with their goals, constituencies, values, and understanding of the political climate, which shapes how they communicate about and fight for them. Actors who pursue unpopular policy goals, for instance, often opt for non-public mobilization strategies such as lobbying, instead of trying to pressure policymakers through public appeals. Most importantly, politics and policy are highly dependent on the structural setting of a specific polity – and therefore so is political communication.

SPOTLIGHTED CONTENT

Political systems can be parliamentary (most European countries) or presidential (e.g. the US, France, and Turkey). Heads of state can be elected directly (France) or indirectly (US and Germany), and there are also constitutional monarchies with royalty that, by birthright, can have real power (e.g. Liechtenstein and Thailand), or be confined to symbolic functions (e.g. the UK, Japan, and Sweden). In the United Arab Emirates, Brunei, Oman, Saudi Arabia, Vatican City, and Eswatini (formerly Swaziland), an absolute monarchy still rules. Political systems can be built around one party (e.g. China), two main parties (US, UK), or multiple parties that may or may not form government coalitions (e.g. Netherlands, Germany, Italy, and Australia), depending on the ideological distance within the party system.

To understand the role of political communication and platforms in politics, and their effects, therefore requires accounting for their embeddedness in political systems. Parliamentary systems tend to be rather stable because parties are a result not only of the electoral system, but also of the social structure and social conflict lines within a society, such as urban and rural, labor and capital, church and state, center and periphery, and the various racial, ethnic, and social identity groups in politics. Political systems can be competitive (mostly in two-party systems) or consociational (aiming to include most groups and interests in society and seeking consensus). These ideal types only rarely exist in the real world, however. For example, in most European countries we find mixed versions (e.g. Belgium, Germany, and Austria).

Party systems can be polarized (mostly in two-party systems) or fragmented, especially where the threshold to enter parliaments is rather low. In the Netherlands, for instance, there is no threshold, and as little as 0.67 percent of votes can be sufficient to gain 1 seat in parliament. In the 2021 election, this resulted in 17 parties being represented in parliament. In most multi-party democracies, there is a threshold around 5 percent, and all parties

below this vote share remain outside of parliamentary representation. This influences how small or new parties campaign, because often this threshold is connected to receiving public financial resources for campaigning.

Political parties are key actors in political communication, and they come in an array of different types. We can differentiate parties along the ideological spectrum (left versus right), their position (in the government versus in the opposition), their size (members or vote share), or group them into party families (such as conservative, progressive, or nationalist). All this impacts how they will engage in political communication or run a campaign. For example, a major incumbent party with a large member base will follow different strategies than a new, small party in a challenger position without a broad member base and with fewer resources. Moreover, parties pursue a variety of objectives that may cause internal conflicts. They might have policy goals (such as a new climate policy) that may be particularly important for the party member base. At the same time, they might also aim at maximizing votes and gaining or keeping office, which may be particularly important for the party elite. Coalition negotiations may lead to conflicts, such as when parties need to decide what is more important to them, their policy agenda or gaining office in a prospective government, or when there are differences in the values, priorities, or goals of the coalition members.

All of these dynamics have significant implications for understanding the strategies behind political communication. A communications campaign may be strategically directed at presenting the party as a viable minor coalition partner, rather than winning, and themes may be chosen accordingly. Party resources have a major impact on campaign strategies. In some countries, parties are based on a membership model (e.g. most European countries), while in other countries parties survive primarily from their supporters' donations and therefore spend more time soliciting wealthy donors and fundraising off of political controversies (e.g. the US). Parties also receive varying degrees of public resources across countries, based on many different regulations and transparency rules.

SPOTLIGHTED CASE

In Switzerland, political parties are treated just like any other private association, with no obligation at all to make their financial assets and revenue transparent, while in many other democracies parties are obliged to publicly report how much they spent on campaigns and where the money came from.

Political communication is indelibly shaped by these features of the polity, such as the institutional dynamics around parties. Election systems are another important variable in political communication. Elections may aim at majority representation (i.e., the party with the highest vote share wins a majority in parliament or the government as a whole). This is mostly the case in two-party systems. It is a system that generally yields clear majorities, creates conditions for stable governments, favors government change with the transfer of power, and enables clear political accountability. On the downside, all votes that were not cast for the winner are generally excluded from power. In contrast, electoral systems aiming at proportional representation favor a fair representation of all voters and are found mostly in multi-party systems, where they yield government coalitions and provide good chances for new and small political parties. On the downside, government coalitions can

more easily break and there are many potential vetoes among minor parties – making wielding power more difficult. This can lead to political instability. Italy is an excellent case to illustrate this, with 67 governments since 1945 at the time of this writing. Finally, campaigning is different in first-order elections (national elections) and second-order elections (regional, local, or transnational elections such as the EU), the latter of which are characterized by lower turnouts, worse prospects for governmental parties, a tendency toward protest voting, and the perception that less is at stake.

Political communication is also shaped by the policies and rules countries create governing things such as elections and campaigning. In many democracies, access to TV and radio airtime is regulated and allocated to parties, for instance, often in ways that reflect their vote share in the last election. Whether and how parties and candidates can buy airtime for political ads influences their campaign strategies. When airtime for ads is equally distributed among parties through regulations, there is no point raising money to buy prime time slots on TV. On the other hand, if a small, new party with limited resources is forced to buy TV airtime and cannot afford it, platforms such as social media might become more central to their campaign strategies.

One reason we see all the varying (and confusing!) implications and effects of platforms in different countries are these differing political systems, democratic institutions and cultures, social structures (such as inequality), and social groups in the polities they are embedded in. The communication of political elites, campaigns, movements, activists, citizens, and government officials does not take place in a vacuum and rarely happens out of thin air. The structure of polities, rules and norms of politics, and existing policies all shape how political communicators use platforms, to what ends, and with what effects.

SPOTLIGHTED CONTENT

To understand the origins, intent, dynamics, and outcomes of political communication, we have to consider the context. Consider a few much focused on examples relevant to democracies around the world today. Small groups who organize and radicalize new members in Facebook or Telegram groups based on deeply rooted ideologies and social identities forged over generations, and then take their messages to the streets or storm political institutions, may not overthrow a stable, consolidated democracy (at least not immediately). They may, however, shake the foundations of a young, barely institutionalized democracy or a sclerotic, dysfunctional regime that has lost the support of its citizens. Elite attempts to polarize citizens for electoral gain using social media might not pose any significant democratic consequences in a parliamentary democracy with strong parties that have to make common cause through coalitional politics to wield power. Those same polarization attempts might look very different, however, in countries with long-standing racial and ethnic animosities, inequalities, histories of violence, and growing economic precarity, or when two parties stand in for very large social divides – such as in the US.

The attempts by an authoritarian leader to gain power might not be a cause for concern in a country with strong parties that reject them, but in moments of crisis or weakness this might open the door to the undoing of democracy.

To summarize, political actors behave and communicate in ways that are structured and incentivized by the political systems they operate in. The structure of the polity, arena of politics, and policy conflicts at stake shape political communication and how political actors use media – even as these things affect the workings of politics in turn (what is known as the “politics–media–politics” model: Wolfsfeld et al. 2022). Because of this, technological and strategic innovations do not always travel well from one nation to another, nor are the effects of platforms the same in every setting (Lorenz-Spreen et al. 2023). All of which is another way of saying that political communication is highly dependent upon the political context in which it takes place, even as media systems also provide the context within which political actors vie for power through communication. We turn now to consider media systems.

2.5 Media Systems and Political Communication: from Mass Media to Platforms

The sociologist Niklas Luhmann (2000) famously argued that whatever we know about society or the world, we know through media. In fact, in their most recent book, *Political Communication in Contemporary India*, Yatindra Singh Sisodia and Pratip Chattopadhyay (2022) spotlight the influential role the media play in shaping political decision-making in the South Asian nation. Hardly anyone has ever met their president, prime minister, or monarch in person, and comparatively few have personally witnessed major historical events first-hand, such as the fall of the Berlin Wall in 1989, the terrorist attacks of September 11, 2001, or the nuclear disaster at Fukushima in 2011. In large, as geographically dispersed societies, we simply cannot eyewitness or experience much of politics first-hand, despite its tremendous impact on our public and personal lives.

As such, political communication is almost *always* mediated. This means that it has to travel from sender(s) to recipient(s) through media of some sort – most commonly in our time mass media and/or digital platforms. Even in-person political events such as candidate speeches are often mediated – by microphones, teleprompters, and staging. Local political events that live audiences can witness directly are often produced for mass mediated audiences (see Lang & Lang 2009). Much of politics is about strategic political actors trying to convey messages through media (such as journalism), ideally without any distortion of the original message. If citizens try to gain the attention of political elites or a broader public, their objective is often to gain as much visibility as possible in the media. Often, these citizen, activist, or movement groups are far more reliant on journalists (what powerful elites say is often *inherently* newsworthy after all!) and have to meet their definitions of what is newsworthy – for example, by creating spectacles that both appear authentic and will play well on television or digital video (Sobieraj 2011). Social media and platforms more generally, however, have provided movements with unprecedented opportunities to gain public visibility, and that has also indelibly shaped journalism and created new forms of public accountability for elites (Richardson 2020).

All of which means that media – understood expansively – are at the core of political communication. Concepts such as the “marketplace of ideas” underline media’s importance to democracy. The media of a particular era significantly impact, shape, and structure political communication. Historically, mass media stood as *the* gateway to the public sphere, the core arena for politics. Today, however, there is what the US legal scholar Yochai Benkler (2006) has called a networked “public sphere” (or space for public

discourse, covered extensively in [Chapter 4](#)), facilitated by platforms that host and gather together many different types of media and political actors. These actors not only use media and platforms to find audiences, they increasingly prioritize media logics (such as performing for television and social media) over political logics (such as engaging in good faith debate with members of the opposing party). Indeed, one of the key sets of documents made publicly available by the US-based Facebook whistleblower Frances Haugen were internal reports at the company that European Union political parties often took more extreme positions on policy issues on social media because they performed better – received more widespread attention, distribution, and engagement.

This shift means significant changes in political communication. We have nearly a century of research on how media select for the information and commentary that journalists and other media actors believe is important, often through professional standards, ideological and identity orientations, and commercial concerns. In the case of legacy media, it is journalists and their news values – “all the news that’s fit to print” is the tagline of the *New York Times* – which shape what information is presented to the public and how. At the same time, these news values also look different across print/text and broadcast, and are also shaped by the audiences represented and appealed to by outlets – for example, partisan media that seek to advance a political agenda, or media rooted in a particular community for which they are an advocate.

In the case of digital platforms, algorithmic systems provide the recommendations that make implicit judgments as to what is important to people and what they will engage with, such as whether it is content shared by close social ties or is similar to content a user has interacted with before. Often, these algorithms are designed to keep users on platforms – ultimately so they can be monetized for the sale of digital ads. Yet some platforms take a more editorial role, such as selecting content to feature (e.g., governmental information during Covid-19), flagging and correcting misinformation (such as when elections are disputed), or designing to promote quality content or “healthy” conversations (such as when Twitter asks you if you want to read something before sharing it). This includes information from government agencies or trusted news sources during elections and public health crises. As we discuss in the next chapter, these are forms of content moderation – broadly, the decisions that platforms make about what content to take down and leave up in accordance with their rules – and take shape according to platforms’ standards, values, and perceived user needs and desires, as well as external pressures from governments, journalists, and civil society organizations.

With media at the core of contemporary political communication, the varieties of media systems matter. Media systems have evolved over time, and the advent of new technologies has transformed them continually, although older technologies rarely become obsolete – instead, newer and older technologies sit side by side. And there is a close relationship between media systems and political systems.

Take news media, for example. While “news” is a centuries-old genre for making society visible to itself (Pettegree 2014), it is not simply a representational media. Newspapers are a global phenomenon, and have been tools for projects of empire and proselytizing. Portuguese missionaries established India’s first printing press (Priolkar 1958). British missionaries are credited with launching newspapers in sub-Saharan Africa. Newspapers have also been vehicles for political projects and diasporic political communities. English-speaking West Africa is often considered the first region on the African continent to embrace newspapers. *The Royal Gazette* and *Sierra Leone Advertiser*, first published in

1801, are touted as the region's oldest newspapers (Mano 2010) (the first printing press brought to Africa in 1792 was destroyed upon arrival [Hunter 2018]). These newspapers were founded by a Black American settler, part of a larger community of many former slaves who escaped from their slave masters and fought for the British during the revolutionary war, and later founded Freetown, Sierra Leone. And Charles L. Force, a former American slave, established the *Royal Gold Coast Gazette*, first published in Ghana in 1794, and later launched the *Liberia Herald* in 1820.

Meanwhile, newspapers and political parties often evolved in tandem in Europe and the United States. In the 1700s and 1800s, many newspapers served as vehicles for political factions and political parties. During this time, politics in many European countries was largely newspaper-based. During the French Revolution, for instance, many politicians started their own newspapers. Between February and March 1789 alone, over 200 newspapers were founded in Paris (Habermas 2013: 277–8). Similarly, in the lead-up to the American Revolution, newspapers helped galvanize widespread frustration about taxes into a union of colonies fighting together for independence. During the 1800s, political parties in the United States and Europe often used newspapers as their organizational basis.

Only during the late 1800s and 1900s did many newspapers in countries such as the US separate from political interests given shifts in economics, printing technology, consumer demand, and reformer desires to have information be free from partisanship so citizens could make up their own minds. With the advancement of printing presses and new commercial models for the press appealing to mass, non-partisan audiences in “democratic market societies” (Schudson 1978) during the late nineteenth century, newspapers became more accessible to and affordable for almost everyone. This continued throughout the first decades of the twentieth century in the United States and Europe, as mass, general-interest newspapers appealed across partisan lines amid a professionalizing journalism project that was codifying its ethics, values, and standards. Unevenly, to be sure, as “yellow” (or sensational) journalism, the racist southern white press in the US that aided and abetted the overthrow of Reconstruction and implementation of Jim Crow segregation, and concerns over tabloids continued to be a feature of journalism throughout the twentieth century in the US (Lippmann 2022; McQueen 2018; Roberts Forde & Bedingfield 2021). And scholars, policymakers, and the public alike worried about the functioning of the mass press given its central importance to US and European political systems, which only grew over the course of the twentieth century. During the peak of the newspaper boom in Europe, in 1929, there were 147 newspapers in Berlin alone, many of them with morning, afternoon, evening, and sometimes even nightly, issues (Patalong 2021).

These concerns about the power of media only grew as the twentieth century witnessed an explosion of new, especially “mass,” media technologies, and the increasingly large-scale adoption of older ones (such as radio). “Mass” is an imprecise concept, but generally refers to the capacity of a medium to reach large audiences (one-to-many, as opposed to one-to-one). With the growth of mass radio and television media, in particular, came concerns about the power of these technologies over the public, with the twentieth century featuring prominent debates over whether these media were strengthening or weakening democracy, or how they were otherwise affecting public life. In reality, media innovations rarely give birth to democracy *or* lead to its destruction. Instead, media get enrolled in what we are already organized to do politically, and they can be directed toward many different ends. While radio enabled citizens to hear the voice of their monarch or president for the first time, it was also an important propaganda tool for the Nazi regime in the 1930s. While TV

brought the US Civil Rights Movement's struggle and presidential debates into living rooms (such as the famous John F. Kennedy versus Richard Nixon American presidential debate) and allowed the entire world to witness mankind's first steps on the Moon, media scholars also feared that we were "amusing ourselves to death" (Postman 2006).

Then along came the Internet and, later, social media, raising initial, overly enthusiastic hopes for the creation of a more inclusive, participatory, deliberative, and indeed global democracy, the end of censorship and big institutions, and, along with the end of the Cold War, "the end of history" (Fukuyama 1989) and the final victory of democracy. By 2016, however, in the wake of that year's United Kingdom European Union membership referendum (i.e., "Brexit") and the election of Donald Trump in the United States, researchers across the world were analyzing a new disinformation disorder, worrying about an epistemic crisis, and arguing that coordinated inauthentic behavior (including by states) and large-scale manipulation of public opinion were undermining democracies around the world. Meanwhile, by 2020 there were growing fears in the United States and Europe that an Internet built largely on American frameworks of "free expression" and "free markets" was becoming "splintered" as countries such as China and Russia developed their own platforms with stricter, state control over expression and information.

Over time, overly utopian and dystopian "techno-deterministic" (the simplistic idea that technologies cause large-scale social and psychological changes) views generally give way to more nuanced and differentiated perspectives on media and communication systems as they actually work within political systems. This resembles the history of research on the effects of media on individuals. Over the past century, analyses of media effects ranged from initial beliefs in strong, linear media effects on citizen's opinions (c.1930s–1950s) to increasingly more sophisticated research traditions that documented how media effects are psychologically, situationally, socially, and contextually dependent (Neuman 2016; Dunaway & Soroka 2021; Neuman & Guggenheim 2011). Most scholars today adopt a model of "contingent effects," detailing things such as the way in which social relationships and social identities shape what people believe, including with regard to the content of news. Researchers have also generally tracked changes in how communication flows, such as a move from direct mass communication from political elites to the public to, increasingly, through networks of social contacts. The latter was always important, but has taken on new prominence now with social media.

All of this tells us that people are rarely dupes of media; they tend to seek out, be exposed to, consume, and believe media in line with their pre-existing identities, social ties, preferences, attitudes, and beliefs. Despite this body of research, fears persist over the power of the media to distort the public sphere, manipulate the masses, and otherwise undermine democracy. In fact, media are often a convenient scapegoat (and an apolitical one) for what are often more fundamental, and irreducibly political, conflicts among social groups over power.

2.6 A Model of Platforms and Political Communication

To sum up, *any* understanding of platforms and political communication requires accounting for the larger media and political systems they are embedded in. Media systems, such as commercial markets for news, the existence of public service broadcasting, and the level of media concentration and media pluralism, have an impact on the ways that elites, journalists, and others engage in political communication, including on

platforms. Media systems and journalism cultures are also a result of political systems and regime types – after all, non-democratic systems may feature higher censorship, lower levels of journalistic professionalization, and less autonomy for journalists than do democratic systems. Even in democratic systems, rising harassment, threats, and violence amid extremism can result in people hiding their political views and organizing in secret (Van Duyn 2021). All of which affect how journalists and citizens use platforms. And, broadly, features of political systems shape the role of platforms within them, such as the ends that political actors pursue, even as the communicative work that gets done on platforms in turn shapes the form and durability of political systems.

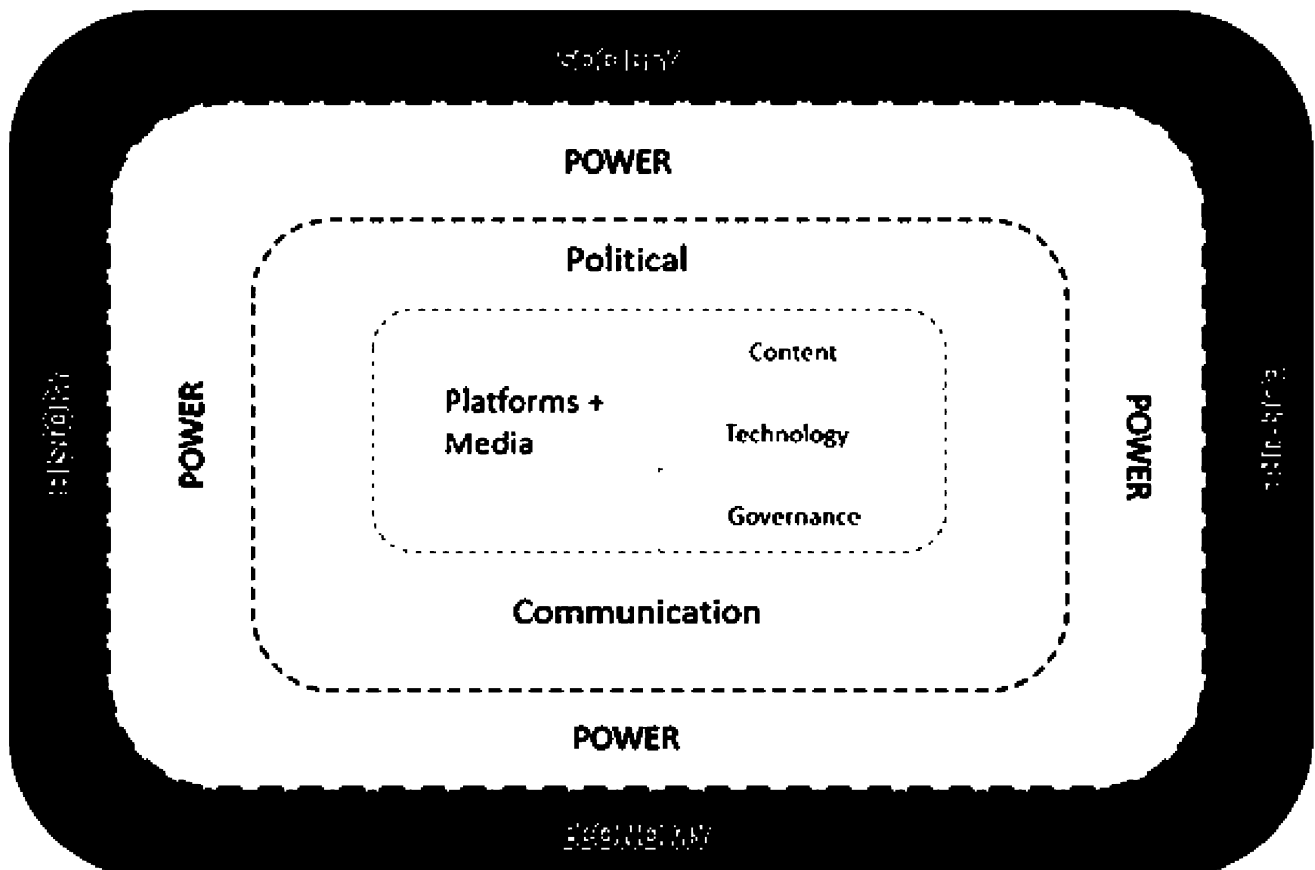


Figure 1 A model of political communication in the digital age. Source: Created by the authors.

We propose the model in [figure 1](#) for the relationship between platforms, political communication, and the embeddedness of both in broader political and media systems.

Let's break down some of these elements.

1. We see platforms at the core of contemporary political communication, alongside other forms of media and arranged into systems. Platforms are increasingly the primary way in which citizens encounter political information and engage with it, as well as communicate with others around things that concern their shared lives. Political *content* on platforms is created by political and media actors of all stripes, including journalists, activists, political strategists, elected officials, and citizens themselves. Platforms are not neutral distribution channels, however. Platform *technologies*, such as their affordances and algorithms, as well as their *governance* – through policies, regulations, business models, and the organizations behind them – shape the ways political content is distributed and flows on and across platforms. In

other words, platforms are not just code. To understand how political communication works on platforms, we need to look beyond the content found on them and reflect also on the technologies and governance that shape how they work, in addition to the dynamics of the political and media systems they are embedded in.

2. Political communication depends highly on context – which is why, even if platforms were the same everywhere (and they are not!), political communication would still be different. If we want to understand the impact of platforms on politics, including their role in political communication phenomena such as disinformation or populism, we must take into account the specific historical, social, cultural, and economic contexts they operate in, as well as the relations of power shaped by these structural forces that play out upon them (Kuo & Marwick 2021). This is why we aim throughout this book to provide examples that go beyond the Western, generally democratic, context of the United States and Europe, and take into account how political communication varies globally, even though people in many nations around the world use the same platforms.
3. The dashed lines in our model capture how power runs in both directions. Power rooted in historical, social, cultural, and economic contexts shapes how political communication operates and the workings of platforms and media. For instance, most platforms are commercial, and therefore operate in capitalistic economic contexts. The historical experiences of nations influence how, and even whether, media and platforms are regulated. For example, media regulation and platform governance in Germany are deeply influenced by the country's Nazi past and the remembrance of genocide (as shown by the country's strong prohibitions against "hate speech" directed at racial, ethnic, and religious minorities, and bans on Holocaust denialism and Nazi propaganda).

Platforms and media, however, have power, too. They do not command armies or shape class structures in society, but the content they differentially host, promote, and disseminate, the technologies they unleash upon society, and their internal governance decisions impact what citizens know (or do not know); what they share, how, and with whom; and how they form opinions, mobilize, or radicalize. Platforms (and media) shape which political actors, wielding which communication styles, gain visibility and attention in ways that affect the workings of political institutions, such as parties. Thus, platforms and media are not just shaped by forms of social, political, cultural, or economic power – they themselves wield power over the societies and political and media systems they operate in.

2.7 Summary

The remainder of this book is about the intersection of these forces. We move through chapters on platforms that detail the ways they are shaped by political and media systems, as well as historical, economic, social, and cultural phenomena, even as they affect these things in turn by providing people and organizations with new capacities to act and communicate. In the end, we embrace the idea that platforms and media and political systems mutually shape one another. Social, political, economic, and historical forces and contexts shape platforms, including how they work, what they are designed to do, their uses in practice, and their applications. But the design and functioning of platforms in turn shape social, political, and economic contexts, and do so throughout time in ways that

shape the future contexts that political actors must navigate. We turn now to focus on platforms.

Discussion Questions

- Political communication varies considerably depending on local context – including political structures, media systems, political cultures, and the historical experiences of countries. What is the most influential institutional feature in your country that shapes political communication?
- This book is based on a very expansive definition of political communication. Think about how to turn this perspective around. What would be the narrowest definition of political communication, and what area(s) would it cover (or not cover)?

Suggestions for Further Reading

Dunaway, J., & Graber, D. A. (2022) *Mass Media and American Politics*. Washington, DC: Congressional Quarterly Press.

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